



BANDEEP SINGH



COMMON GROUND:
The representative
significance of the game
brings people together

The Passion

NO SPORT CAN TRANSCEND
THE SOCIETY IN WHICH IT IS
PLAYED, BUT CRICKET AS A
TOTEM OF DIVERSITY DOES
ITS JOB ADMIRABLY WELL

PLAY

BY MUKUL KESAVAN

There are people in India who never vote, who don't watch Hindi films and who make a habit of loudly declaring that they can't fathom what people see in cricket. Such men are dangerous. To be apolitical is a short step from being disaffected, to shun mainstream cinema is a symptom of alienation, but it is the ostentatious indifference to cricket that marks out the rudderless malcontent lost to all civic or national virtue.

Seriously, though, does a passion for cricket help national communities overcome social divisions? There is some anecdotal evidence that it does. In the colonial territories of the Caribbean populated by slave and indentured labour who were held down by racism, cricket became both a proving ground for the equal potential of black people and a force that briefly created a Caribbean 'nation' each time the West Indies took the field.